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Aigerim Bayanbayeva

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Global university rankings and the dissemination of the Western university model: balancing global influence and national priorities in Kazakhstan

Aigerim Bayanbayeva 

Centre for Higher Education Transformations, School of Education, University of Bristol, Bristol, UK

ABSTRACT

Global university rankings (GURs) play a key role in shaping higher education (HE) systems worldwide, often promoting the adoption of the Western university model. By prioritising metrics such as research output, these rankings inherently reflect Western academic norms, creating tensions between global standards and local educational priorities. This study examines the integration of the Western university model in Kazakhstan's HE system, focusing on the influence of GURs as neo-colonial power structures. Interviews with 17 participants at a leading university in Kazakhstan revealed mixed responses: while some see value in aligning with Western practices to improve HE, most are concerned about the potential loss of national identity. In addition, several participants expressed nostalgia for the Soviet HE system. The study highlights how Kazakhstan's top-down governance model and coercive policy pressures have driven universities to conform to GURs metrics, often at the expense of institutional autonomy and contextual relevance, illustrating that academic imperialism is not only externally imposed but also internally reinforced through domestic policy choices. It concludes that the government's uncritical adoption of Western policies, without adequate consideration of local contexts, including universities' research capacities, perpetuates a distorted version of the Western university model.

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Introduction

Globalisation and the growing prominence of GURs have led to significant shifts in the ways developing countries structure HE systems, with increasing influence from Western academic models. As GURs become a dominant measure of academic prestige and institutional success, the pressure to conform to internationally recognised academic standards has intensified (Erkkilä and Piironen 2020; Hazelkorn 2015; Rhein and Nanni 2021). Kazakhstan, with its ambitious aim of becoming a regional educational hub, exemplifies this trend as it adopts GURs to elevate the quality and prestige of its HE system (Anafinova 2020; Bayanbayeva 2024).

As a post-Soviet country, Kazakhstan inherited a centralised HE system focused on alignment with state directives. During the Soviet period, HE in Kazakhstan operated under a centralised and state-planned system focused on specialised training and ideological conformity. Academic freedom and institutional autonomy were limited (Oleksiyenko 2021). The Soviet model of the university was designed primarily as a teaching institution, while research was carried out in specialised

CONTACT Aigerim Bayanbayeva  di18366@bristol.ac.uk  Centre for Higher Education Transformations, School of Education, University of Bristol, 35 Berkeley Square, Bristol, BS8 1JA, UK

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institutes affiliated with the Academy of Sciences, resulting in a strict institutional separation between HE and research (Chankseliani, Fedyukin, and Frumin 2022; Huisman, Smolentseva, and Froumin 2018). This legacy of the Soviet model continues to shape the research landscape in post-Soviet countries, but varying reform trajectories have produced divergent patterns of integration between HE and research sectors (Lovakov, Chankseliani, and Panova 2022). Following independence in 1991, Kazakhstan entered a period of post-Soviet transition characterised by institutional fragmentation, underfunding, and the gradual dismantling of Soviet structures (Huisman, Smolentseva, and Froumin 2018). This period was also marked by early attempts to internationalise HE through initiatives such as the Bolashak scholarship programme and partnerships with foreign institutions (Altynbassov et al. 2021; Hwami 2024; Jonbekova et al. 2023). In the 2010s, Kazakhstan accelerated reforms under the influence of globalisation and neoliberal policy models, joining the Bologna Process and introducing Western-style standards. As part of these initiatives, Kazakhstan has embraced Western academic frameworks, curriculum designs, and research practices (Ambasz et al. 2023; Hwami 2024; Lodhi and Ilyassova-Schoenfeld 2022; Mukhamejanova and Kuchumova 2024). With the growing influence of GURs, Kazakhstan seeks to enhance its universities' standings, which play a significant role in shaping the nation's HE policies (Anafinova 2020; Bayanbayeva 2024). The strategic importance of GURs is highlighted in key national documents, such as The State Programme for the Development of Education and Science of the Republic of Kazakhstan for 2020–2025, which sets specific goals for improving national universities' rankings. However, since GURs inherently favour higher education institutions (HEIs) in Anglo-European countries (Marginson 2022; Stack 2021), Kazakhstani universities face significant challenges in competing on the global stage. Additionally, balancing the preservation of local priorities with the demands of globalisation and aligning with international standards presents a complex and ongoing challenge (Wang, Sung, and Vong 2021). Despite the growing recognition of these issues, there is a lack of empirical research on how post-Soviet HE systems, particularly in Central Asia, experience and respond to these pressures. Existing studies often focus on policy-level analysis or document analysis (Anafinova 2020; Lee and Naidoo 2020), overlooking the perspectives of institutional actors who are directly involved in this transformation. The present study addresses this gap by examining how academics and university leadership in Kazakhstan perceive and adapt to the influence of GURs and the Western university model, providing insight into the hybridisation of global norms within a culturally and historically distinct HE system. Using the framework of academic imperialism, the study critically examines how the adoption of Western academic standards influences the HE system in Kazakhstan. This research contributes to the broader discourse on the impact of globalisation on HE in developing countries, with a particular focus on the challenges of balancing global influence with national priorities.

Literature review

Globalisation and internationalisation have significantly reshaped global HE, with GURs acting as key drivers of this transformation (de Lee and Stensaker 2021; Wit and Altbach 2020). GURs such as the QS World University Rankings and the Times Higher Education World University Rankings, play a crucial role in influencing institutional reputations and guiding policy decisions in HE (Ahlers and Christmann-Budian 2023; Escandon-Barbosa, Salas-Paramo, and Moreno-Gómez 2023). GURs facilitate the internationalisation of HE by standardising and comparing university performance globally, often reinforcing the dominance of Western institutions, particularly those in the USA and UK (Escandon-Barbosa, Salas-Paramo, and Moreno-Gómez 2023; Robertson and Olds 2016). Consequently, the Western university model, defined by principles such as academic freedom, institutional self-governance, and a focus on research-oriented education, is commonly regarded as a benchmark for excellence and closely aligns with the idea of a 'world-class university' (Li and Eryong 2020; Shattock 2017). This has sparked broader concerns about the spread of the Western university model and the risks of global convergence and homogenisation

in HE practices, which may undermine diversity and local educational priorities (Ordorika and Lloyd 2015; Shahjahan, Ramirez, and Andreotti 2017).

The impact of GURs on national HE systems varies depending on factors such as country size, socio-economic conditions, and institutional contexts (Gornitzka 2013; Hazelkorn 2015). Gornitzka (2013) identifies three national responses to GURs: channelling (directly using GURs metrics in policy), buffering (isolating national policies from GURs), and filtering (selecting certain GURs prescriptions). In countries such as China, Japan, and South Korea, where research universities are key to economic development, GURs metrics are actively channelled into policy decisions (Do and Mai 2022; Kang and Mok 2024). In contrast, Nordic countries are more selective, filtering the influence of GURs on their policies (Kohvakka and Nevala 2023). These varied national responses highlight the significant influence of GURs in shaping HE reforms, as countries seek to enhance their universities' competitiveness and international recognition (Ahlers and Christmann-Budian 2023; Do and Mai 2022; Erkkilä and Piironen 2020). Governments use GURs to position universities in the global HE market, with some countries launching national initiatives to improve their universities' rankings. Notable examples include Germany's Excellence Initiative, France's Initiatives D'Excellence, China's 985 Project and Double First-Class strategy (Guo et al. 2023; Han, Zha, and Xie 2023).

Although Kazakhstan has not launched a dedicated national excellence initiative, the strategic focus on GURs is explicitly reflected in national policy agendas. Key strategic and policy documents stress the importance of GURs in developing national HE sector. Accordingly, HEIs have adjusted their internal performance criteria to align with ranking indicators by prioritising research performance and internationalisation (Anafinova 2020; Bayanbayeva 2024). Anafinova (2020) argues that this shift in national universities in Kazakhstan toward alignment with GURs metrics has been driven by coercive policy pressures. This has led HEIs to adopt the Anglo-American research university model, prioritising research, even at the cost of institutional diversity. These developments highlight the ambiguous influence of GURs on institutional priorities and the strategic orientation of Kazakhstani HEIs.

Furthermore, there is growing concern about the neo-colonial implications of GURs, as they may perpetuate existing power imbalances and undermine the distinct educational identities and priorities of non-Western institutions (Enslin and Hedge 2023; Guzmán-Valenzuela 2023; Lloyd and Ordorika 2021; Shahjahan and Morgan 2016). Guzmán-Valenzuela (2023) argues that GURs represent a new form of colonialism, promoting a 'world-class university' model that emphasises prestige, competition, and internationalisation. This model is primarily rooted in Western ideals of academic productivity and research excellence, which disadvantages Latin American universities that struggle to achieve similar standings. As a result, these institutions often emulate Western practices and frameworks, leading to a dependency that undermines local knowledge and contexts. Similarly, Lloyd and Ordorika (2021) highlight that GURs serve as a form of cultural imperialism, imposing a specific, US-based model of HE as the global standard. This model privileges certain aspects of universities, such as research production, scientific output, and prestige, while sidelining other values such as teaching quality, social equity, and local development priorities. GURs, despite being presented as objective and neutral, reflect the values and priorities of elite Anglo-Saxon universities, and thus perpetuate global inequalities by favouring institutions that align with this model. The authors conclude that this has deep colonial implications, as it marginalises non-Western educational models and imposes a narrow vision of what constitutes 'excellence' in HE. Ultimately, the pervasive influence of GURs threatens to deepen global inequalities in HE by privileging Western-centric notions of excellence, marginalising diverse educational models, and compromising the autonomy and priorities of non-Western HEIs.

In that sense, gaining a deeper understanding of the experiences of university academics and leadership in Kazakhstan becomes crucial, as it provides valuable insights into how HEIs in the Global South navigate these challenges and assert their educational priorities within a globally unequal landscape. Specifically, whether Kazakhstan's HEIs are experiencing forms of academic dependency

that align with the theory of academic imperialism. This could involve the ways in which Kazakhstani HEIs adopt Western academic models, curricula, and research frameworks, often at the expense of local knowledge, culture, and academic traditions.

Theoretical framework

This study draws on the theory of academic imperialism, as it provides a useful perspective for explaining the growing hegemony of GURs in the HE systems of developing countries and therefore can conceptualise the influence of GURs in national contexts. This theory is rooted in the ideas of imperialism theories, which stress the unequal development of different countries and define imperialism as ‘the practice, theory, and the attitudes of a dominant metropolitan centre ruling in a distant territory’ (Said 1993). Academic imperialism as a form of Western imperialism tries to reinforce the idea that the HE system of Western countries is the best model that should be disseminated in the Third World, which has led to inequality between academia in developed and developing countries (Lloyd and Ordorika 2021; Shahjahan and Morgan 2016). In this regard, Altbach (2012) argues that the advancement of Western knowledge created centres and peripheries in HE. Since academic imperialism is less conspicuous and indirect compared to other types of imperialism such as political or economic imperialism, it softly imposes Western epistemology in the development of HE and research in developing countries (Zeiny 2019). Due to the rapid expansion of globalisation and internationalisation in HE, academic imperialism as a new form of colonialism can be manifested in the influence of GURs, the dominance of English and English-language journals and databases in academia, the spread of idea of the Western university model, academic mobility of students and faculty as well as the opening branches of the Western universities (Lloyd and Ordorika 2021; Shahjahan and Morgan 2016). Shahjahan and Morgan (2016) contend that the influence of GURs extends beyond mere competition, emphasising that these rankings are also deeply embedded in processes of coloniality. They argue that coloniality plays a central role in shaping and sustaining the competitive dynamics of GURs, as it reinforces hierarchical structures of knowledge production and institutional prestige, privileging certain epistemologies and universities, primarily from the Global North, while marginalising others.

A development in the theory of academic imperialism has pointed out that academic imperialism gives rise to academic dependency – the dependency of non-Western universities and researchers on Western academia (Alatas 2003). Actually, the notion of academic dependency is useful to explain how HEIs from developing countries are adopting western policies. Alatas (2003) identifies several manifestations of academic dependency, including dependence on ideas, dependence on the media of ideas, dependence on the technology of education, dependence on aid for research as well as teaching, dependence on investment in education, and dependence of Third World social scientists on demand in the West for their skills. In this context, academic imperialism is sustained through such dependencies.

In Kazakhstan, the mechanisms of academic imperialism and dependency are reinforced through a combination of state-driven modernisation policies, centralised governance structures, and a persistent prestige orientation rooted in post-Soviet political logics. The government’s aspiration to modernise and internationalise HE, often through alignment with Western models, is deeply embedded in its broader agenda of portraying Kazakhstan as a progressive, globally integrated nation. Policies such as the Bolashak scholarship programme, which sends students and scholars to study at Western universities (Jonbekova et al. 2023), and the Nazarbayev University model, explicitly designed in collaboration with Western partners (Sabzalieva 2017), signal a deliberate state-led effort to replicate Western universities. Furthermore, national policy and strategic documents explicitly ties the success of national universities to their positions in GURs, reinforcing a metrics-driven, Western-centric vision of HE quality (Anafinova 2020; Bayanbayeva 2024). This has created pressure on universities to conform to Western academic models – often through top-down mandates to increase publications in international journals, improve international

visibility, and emulate globally ranked institutions. Thus, these dynamics illustrates how GURs are not merely tools for benchmarking, but powerful mechanisms of influence that embed Western norms and drive national policies toward conformity with externally defined standards of academic excellence.

Methodology

This study employs a qualitative research design to examine the dynamics of adopting Western university model within Kazakhstan's HE system. The study was conducted at one of Kazakhstan's leading national research universities, which is widely recognised for its strategic emphasis on improving its ranking position and expanding global partnerships. It comprises 13 faculties offering a wide range of undergraduate, graduate, and doctoral programmes. The university's institutional strategy focuses on strengthening its position as a research-intensive institution. Key development areas include promotion of advanced scientific technologies, enhancing the quality of academic programmes and research productivity and expanding international cooperation and aligning with global education standards. It is one of 21 HEIs in Kazakhstan that are ranked in major GURs. Thus, it serves as a representative case of a high-performing, globally oriented Kazakhstani HEI undergoing reform.

A total of 17 participants were purposively selected, reflecting both senior leadership and academic staff involved in institutional governance and academic development. The sample comprised 8 academics and 9 members of senior leadership, including 1 vice-rector, 3 deans, and 5 heads of departments. Of the 17 participants, 5 were female and 12 were male. In terms of disciplinary background, 6 participants were from STEM and 11 participants from non-STEM faculties. These participants were purposefully selected for their direct involvement in decision-making related to research strategy, internationalisation, and curriculum development. Their institutional roles provide them with in-depth insights into how GURs and the Western university model influence policy and practice at the university level. This purposive sampling ensured that the participants had the necessary expertise and experience to offer valuable insights into the research topic (Creswell and Creswell 2022).

Data were collected through semi-structured interviews, conducted over a period of two months. A semi-structured interview method was chosen to enable a thorough exploration of participants' perspectives, while also allowing flexibility to explore emerging themes during the discussions (Maxwell 2013). Each interview lasted between 45 and 90 min, providing ample time for a thorough exploration of participants' views on the adoption of GURs and their perceptions of the Western academic model. All interviews were conducted in person, in the participants' preferred language, ensuring that language barriers did not hinder the depth of the data. With the participants' consent, the interviews were audio-recorded and subsequently transcribed verbatim for analysis.

The transcribed interview data were analysed using thematic analysis, as outlined by Braun and Clarke (2021). This approach involves systematically identifying, analysing, and reporting patterns (themes) within the data. The analysis followed a six-step process: familiarisation with the data by repeatedly reading the transcripts; generating initial codes by identifying and labelling meaningful segments of the data that align with the research questions; searching for themes by grouping related codes into broader, overarching categories; reviewing themes to verify their consistency and alignment with the research questions; defining and naming themes that accurately capture the data; producing the report.

Ethical approval for the study was granted by the university's ethics review board. Participants were given informed consent forms detailing the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of their participation, and their right to withdraw at any time without any negative consequences.

While the study focuses on a single institution, which may limit generalisability, this university was purposefully chosen for its prominence in GURs and its active role in state-led reforms, making it a critical case. Furthermore, given Kazakhstan's top-down HE governance, practices observed

here are likely to reflect broader trends. Moreover, many participants had experience across multiple universities, allowing for insights that extend beyond the selected university.

Findings

The findings regarding the adoption of the Western university model in Kazakhstan through GURs reflect a complex and multifaceted discussion among participants, revealing both support and resistance. The data reveals three major themes: support for the Western university model, concerns regarding national identity and socio-economic differences, and reflections on the legacy of the Soviet HE system. A critical analysis of these findings highlights the tension between globalisation and local relevance, as well as the challenges associated with borrowing international best practices in the context of Kazakhstan.

Support for the Western university model

The findings suggest that participants largely view GURs as a key factor in promoting the adoption of the Western university model in developing countries. Some participants expressed support for implementing aspects of the Western university model within the context of Kazakhstan, highlighting its potential to modernise and improve the HE sector in Kazakhstan. They highlighted key characteristics of Western HE and stressed that the well-established HE practices in developed countries could play a crucial role in advancing the HE system in Kazakhstan:

I do not perceive the spread of the Western university model in developing countries as a threat. Instead, we should recognise the success of this model and focus on leveraging its strengths to enhance our own HE system. (P5, Vice-Rector)

Adopting a Western university model is likely to have a positive effect on our HE system. It would lead to a gradual improvement in the quality of national HEIs. In the long term, this model could significantly contribute to the nation's overall development and economic growth. (P3, Dean)

It is evident that GURs promote the Western education model. However, practice has demonstrated that this model is indeed effective. Hypothetically, if another university model had proven to be successful, we would have observed its achievements in practice and likely been inclined to adopt it. (P9, Head of Department)

This optimism stems from the tangible successes of Western universities, particularly in areas such as research output, academic integrity, and global collaboration. Participants highlighted the advanced research practices of Western universities. According to the participants, the Western university model embodies and promotes values such as institutional self-governance and the pursuit of liberal academic knowledge. The following excerpts provide examples of the various benefits attributed to the Western university model:

The first universities were indeed established in Western Europe, and there is much to learn from their long-standing traditions. While the Soviet Union developed its own distinguished model of universities, in the 21st century, this model has struggled to foster research and collaboration with industry. In contrast, Western universities are distinguished by their commitment to academic integrity, openness, and global collaboration. A key strength of the Western model is its ability to integrate research with business. Importantly, adopting this model does not imply a loss of national values or a threat to cultural identity. (P7, Academic)

I believe that leading Western universities, such as Stanford and Harvard, exemplify the ideal model of HEIs. For instance, Stanford University is situated near Silicon Valley, home to hundreds of companies with turnovers in the billions and trillions of dollars. This proximity fosters innovation and research collaboration. We should draw from the best practices of Western universities, particularly in advancing research and innovation, to enhance our own HE system. (P17, Head of Department)

These interview excerpts reflect participants' admiration for the Western university model, citing its strengths in research output, academic integrity, and collaboration with industry. However, most participants expressed concerns about national identity and socio-economic differences, fearing

that adopting the Western university model might undermine local cultural values and create inequalities.

Concerns regarding national identity and socio-economic differences

The findings reveal significant concerns about the risks associated with the spread of the Western university model. Most participants perceived it as a vehicle for the dissemination of Western ideologies in developing countries. They emphasised the profound socio-economic disparities between Western and developing nations and expressed fears that adopting this model could contribute to the erosion of national identity. They contended that implementing this model without necessary adaptations may prioritise Western standards and values, potentially marginalising local knowledge systems, cultural values, and national priorities:

The Erasmus Mundus programme and other foreign-funded initiatives have a considerable influence on our local education system. The underlying reason for foreign countries to finance such programmes is to promote their own educational models and methodologies in developing nations such as Kazakhstan. Through these initiatives, they disseminate their approaches and strengthen their influence within the global HE landscape. (P6, Academic)

Participants also stressed the role of GURs in advancing the Western university model, arguing that these rankings prioritise Western policies and practices. This, they contended, poses a significant challenge to developing nations in preserving their educational autonomy:

In the development of our universities, we often prioritise integration into the global arena through GURs without adequately considering national characteristics. It is essential to recognise that private ranking companies are often influenced by Western policies and ideologies, and developing countries allocate significant funds to these ranking companies. Western countries have structured GURs to serve their interests, hindering the independent development of nation-states, particularly developing countries. This reflects a coercive policy framework. (P4, Academic)

When our universities are evaluated by the same criteria as those in the US or UK, it becomes difficult not to adopt their strategies. The focus on research and publishing in high-impact journals is one example. But we do not always have the same resources, and our local priorities are different. We are expected to conform to western ideals of excellence, even though they may not fully reflect our educational and developmental needs. (P2, Academic)

Thus, concerns about socio-economic differences between Western and developing countries raise doubts about the applicability of the Western university model in Kazakhstan. The critique here is not necessarily against the Western university model itself, but rather its unsuitability in contexts where the infrastructure, funding, and societal conditions do not mirror those of the West:

The model followed by many Western universities is largely based on the Anglo-Saxon tradition. However, the technologies and methodological frameworks they bring may not produce favourable outcomes in our country because of significant differences in social and economic contexts. These disparities can create challenges in effectively applying these models within our local HE system. (P2, Academic)

Moreover, most participants highlighted the unequal position of researchers from developing countries when it comes to publishing articles in international peer-reviewed journals. They pointed out that the language barrier, limited access to global research networks, and unequal resources create significant challenges for researchers in Kazakhstan. This discrepancy reflects broader issues in the adoption of the Western university model, where the focus on English-language publications and Western-style research marginalises local academic practices and knowledge production:

The government is placing increasing pressure on us to publish, but as I am not proficient in English, I have to rely on my colleagues to include me as a co-author. While the government mandates publications in English, there is a clear shortage of English proficiency among faculty members. (P1, Head of Department)

We are expected to publish in Scopus, deliver high-quality education, and participate in research projects, yet the university fails to provide adequate funding or competitive salaries. (P4, Academic)

Although publication in Scopus and Web of Science journals is mandated, many academics in Kazakhstan remain unfamiliar with Western academic standards and methodologies. Unfortunately, the university leadership often neglects this issue. (P17, Head of Department)

These concerns highlight the importance of contextual adaptation in HE reform. Some participants argued that Kazakhstani HEIs should prioritise the unique characteristics of the national HE system, particularly the legacy of the Soviet educational framework. They criticised Western ideologies for putting academics from non-English-speaking countries at a disadvantage, suggesting that such biases may impede their contributions and limit opportunities for collaboration within the global academic community:

Many universities in both developed and developing countries strive to emulate elite institutions that rank highly in GURs. However, it is crucial for us to cultivate our own unique strengths. In engaging with GURs, we must ensure that we do not compromise our national characteristics or identity. (P15, Dean)

Reflections on the legacy of the Soviet higher education system

Several participants conveyed nostalgic sentiments regarding the advancements in research and education during the Soviet period as well as strong links between academia and specific economic sectors. They reflected on the challenges faced by the current system and the impact of these changes on the quality and effectiveness of HE:

During the Soviet period, there was a clear separation between education and research, exemplified by the presence of the Academy of Sciences and specialised research institutes that were integral to training professionals and conducting research relevant to specific economic sectors. In contrast, our current system lacks this clarity, and we are also facing challenges in adapting to Western models. This lack of distinction may jeopardise the development of a whole generation of researchers, hindering their potential contributions to the field. (P2, Academic)

This separation between HE and research referred to the organisational structure in the Soviet Union, in which universities focused on teaching, while research was conducted exclusively in institutes under the Academy of Sciences. In contrast, the post-independence era saw the dismantling or weakening of many of these research institutions, with universities expected to assume both teaching and research functions, often without adequate funding, infrastructure, or human capacity.

Another unique insight emerged in relation to how the Soviet HE model is perceived internationally:

Our researchers who visited European universities were astonished to discover the high regard with which the Soviet model of HE is viewed. European colleagues informed them that Scandinavian countries, Japan, and China have successfully implemented HE reforms inspired by the Soviet model, while we seem to be adopting programmes designed for third countries. This highlights a missed opportunity to leverage our historical educational strengths in our own reform efforts. (P6, Academic)

While this perspective reveals a sense of missed potential in Kazakhstan's HE reform trajectory, participants were not universally critical of the Western university model. Many acknowledged its value in promoting international collaboration and research visibility, but stressed the need for context-sensitive hybrid models rather than uncritical adoption:

During the Soviet period, there was a clear understanding of the university's purpose. Today, under the influence of Western ideologies, we strive to become research universities. While I acknowledge the research achievements of Western universities, we do not have the same resources and capacities. Now, we are chasing numbers. Our identity is lost in someone else's metrics. (P16, Academic)

The Soviet university model contributed significantly to education and research in its time, but its time has passed. Today, the Western university model dominates in national reforms. However, we do not need to copy Western systems word for word. What we need is a model that works for our reality. (P5, Vice-Rector)

These reflections suggest that the Soviet legacy continues to shape how Kazakhstani academics and university leadership conceptualise the role of university in society. Many participants stressed the importance of taking into account Kazakhstan's historical background and the actual capacity of its universities when planning and implementing HE reforms. Overall, participants perceived the Western university model as a product of the influence exerted by GURs. Notably, even those participants who expressed resistance to the idea of adopting the Western university model acknowledged the valuable experience of Western universities in fostering research advancements.

Discussion

This study presents a nuanced and complex perspective on the adoption of the Western university model in Kazakhstan, particularly through the influence of GURs. The key themes identified offer valuable insights into the tension between globalisation and preserving local priorities. This tension is emblematic of a broader global challenge where educational policies and models, often originating in economically dominant Western countries, are superimposed onto diverse local contexts without sufficient adaptation or consideration of local needs and values (Lloyd and Ordorika 2021; Saito et al. 2023).

The findings highlight the complex interplay between global influences and national educational policies. The support for adopting aspects of the Western university model among participants reflects an understanding of the benefits that these systems can bring to Kazakhstan's HE landscape. The emphasis on global recognition, research excellence, and university-industry collaboration highlights the attraction of Western universities' success in areas such as research output and institutional governance. These elements are indeed strengths of the Western university models and can be considered as potential drivers of Kazakhstan's development in both HE and economic growth. However, as Tomlinson and Watermeyer (2020) argue, aligning with market driven HE models can fuel credential inflation and deepen structural inequalities. Furthermore, while this support for the Western university model is compelling, it may also overestimate the ease with which Kazakhstan can adopt these practices. Assuming that Western academic standards can be directly implemented in Kazakhstan disregards the need to tailor these practices to the country's unique socio-political and cultural environment (Ambasz et al. 2023; Lodhi and Ilyassova-Schoenfeld 2022). Moreover, the Soviet legacy poses challenges to the policy transfer of Western educational practices in post-communist states, resulting in their partial adoption (Ilyassova-Schoenfeld 2023). Implementing Western academic practices in developing countries, where infrastructure, financial resources, and societal conditions may not match those of Western nations raises significant concerns about the feasibility and sustainability of such an approach (Ambasz et al. 2023; Moshtari and Safarpour 2024; Tight 2022). Additionally, the focus on GURs and university research performance often disadvantages universities in developing countries, as they lack equal access to leading international publications and collaborative opportunities (Heng 2023; Kuzhabekova 2020). The primary reasons for this issue include a lack of proficiency in English, unfamiliarity with Western academic writing standards, limited exposure to Western research methodologies and theoretical frameworks, restricted access to global literature and databases, and insufficient state funding (Altynbassov et al. 2024; Kuzhabekova 2020). At the same time, governments in developing countries are adopting Western policies without fully considering the local context. As a result, academics from developing countries often resort to questionable and manipulative practices, such as gift authorship and publishing in predatory journals, in order to meet the pressures and demands of government-imposed performance metrics (Bayanbayeva 2024; Marina and Sterligov 2021). This leads to an increase in the number of low-quality articles, further distorting the application of the Western university model in the Global South. Consequently, the pursuit of international recognition through such practices undermines the integrity of research and perpetuates a flawed version of the Western university model. Furthermore, the uncritical adoption of Western educational models risks exacerbating inequalities, promoting cultural homogenisation, and reinforcing the dominance of the

Global North in shaping global educational policies, ultimately serving as a manifestation of academic imperialism (Lloyd and Ordorika 2021; Marginson 2022; Rocha et al. 2023). The key challenge is to ensure that HE reforms in Kazakhstan are aligned with the local context, culturally appropriate, and responsive to the needs and aspirations of the local population, rather than being driven solely by external pressures or the quest for international recognition. A vivid example of this process is China's gradual shift from adopting Western academic standards and ranking criteria. After years of aligning with GURs and Western standards, China is now moving towards developing its evaluation systems, reflecting a more nationalist approach, where 'Chinese university will remain to be the Chinese version of Western university' (Ahlers and Christmann-Budian 2023; Kang and Mok 2024; Wang, Sung, and Vong 2021). Thus, Chinese universities are redefining their identity by integrating global best practices while prioritising indigenous values and national priorities.

Another key finding is the concerns expressed by many participants about the potential erosion of national identity and values due to the adoption of Western education models. The influence of GURs plays a key role in this concern, acting as a form of 'soft power' where Western universities shape global expectations and practices by dominating these rankings (Lo 2011). GURs establish the standards for 'excellence' in HE, influencing both institutional reputations and shaping HE policies and funding (Marginson 2022; Stack 2021). This creates a subtle global influence where developing countries may feel inclined to adopt Western practices, driven not by direct pressure, but by the desire for international recognition and academic prestige. However, this can lead to fears that embracing Western practices might marginalise local knowledge, cultural values, and national priorities. Such concerns often stem from the fear of cultural imperialism, where Western ideologies risk overshadowing and replacing local traditions and values (Lloyd and Ordorika 2021; Rocha et al. 2023). These concerns are particularly significant in a post-Soviet context, where Kazakhstan, similar to other former Soviet republics, is still navigating its identity in a globalised world (Gallo 2021). Despite concerns about decolonisation, Kazakhstan continues to adopt Western educational models, reinforcing a hierarchical global education structure (Hwami 2024). Therefore, there is a strong call for a more thoughtful approach that considers Kazakhstan's unique cultural, economic, and historical context. This approach should involve setting feasible goals for HEIs and critically evaluating the effects of adopting Western educational models to create a strategy that better aligns with the country's unique needs and aspirations. However, it is important to acknowledge that academic imperialism in Kazakhstan is not just externally imposed – it is internally reproduced through domestic policies that prioritise aligning with Western standards. Coercive policy pressures have pushed Kazakhstani HEIs to align with GURs metrics, leading to the adoption of the Western university model (Anafinova 2020; Bayanbayeva 2024). As a result, HEIs in Kazakhstan have prioritised research performance, often restructuring institutional policies to favour international publications and citation-based outputs. In practice, universities also engage in strategic responses, ranging from selective implementation of reforms to tactical behaviours aimed at improving ranking positions, such as incentivising publications in indexed journals. In some cases, institutions engage in manipulative practices that exploit ranking metrics to advance institutional position in GURs (Bayanbayeva 2024). This has fuelled growing concern that the uncritical adoption of Western norms may undermine the unique character of the national HE system.

While HEIs in Kazakhstan have increasingly aligned with GURs, the government has also implemented national evaluation mechanisms to complement these global metrics. For instance, the Independent Agency for Quality Assurance in Education and the Independent Agency for Accreditation and Rating have developed national university rankings that assess HEIs based on criteria such as academic mobility and the competitiveness of publications (Kerimkulova and Kuzhabekova 2017). However, these national rankings often mirror the priorities of GURs, emphasising research output and international visibility, which may inadvertently perpetuate academic dependency. At the institutional level, universities have formulated strategic plans and internal policies to define their research and academic priorities (Bayanbayeva 2024; Mukhamejanova and Kuchumova

2024). Nevertheless, the overarching emphasis on improving standings in GURs overshadow these localised objectives, limiting the scope for academic autonomy. Moreover, the centralised, top-down approach to HE policy in Kazakhstan reinforces alignment with externally defined metrics, leaving limited space for bottom-up strategies.

The legacy of the Soviet HE system is another crucial element in understanding the current discourse surrounding the Western university model. Findings indicate that the structure and values of the Soviet system continue to inform how globalisation is experienced and contested in Kazakhstan's HE sector. The legacy of top-down governance normalises compliance with external standards while simultaneously fuelling resistance to perceived epistemic colonisation. This reflects a clash between Western academic values such as competition, autonomy, and innovation, and Kazakhstan's historical and cultural traditions, where such approaches may feel unfamiliar or difficult to implement effectively. Several participants highlighted the strengths of the Soviet HE system, particularly its focus on research and the distinct separation between HE and research, which was closely linked to specific economic sectors (Lovakov, Chankseliani, and Panova 2022). This division may have allowed for a more direct alignment between academic research and industry needs, something that is not always evident in the current system. However, while nostalgia for the Soviet period is present, it is important to recognise that the Soviet system also had significant limitations, especially in terms of academic freedom, global integration, and limited international research collaboration (Chankseliani 2022; Oleksienko 2021). The desire to revert to this model may overlook the broader shifts in global HE, such as the rise of interdisciplinary research, the diverse missions of universities, and the growth of international collaboration. Therefore, while the strengths of the Soviet HE system should be acknowledged, it may not provide a fully viable HE model for Kazakhstan's future development.

It is also important to critically assess how the shift to the Western university model, especially through the lens of GURs, has not only introduced new expectations but has arguably marginalised local intellectual traditions and cultural values. Participants raised concerns about the loss of national priorities in research, the dominance of English-language publishing, and the performative focus on quantity over quality. However, the discussion could go further by problematising the binary framing of Soviet versus Western models. Rather than viewing these models as mutually exclusive, it would be more productive to consider how hybrid institutional arrangements can be developed – ones that preserve contextual strengths (such as sectoral engagement and social relevance) while promoting internationalisation and academic autonomy. In summary, while the pursuit of higher rankings in GURs and the adoption of the Western university model may offer certain benefits, such as global recognition, they also raise significant concerns about cultural dilution and practical relevance. A careful, context-sensitive approach that balances the benefits of Western academic practices with respect for national identity and socio-economic realities will be essential for the successful transformation of Kazakhstan's HE system.

Conclusion

This study examines the complex dynamics of adopting the Western university model and participating in GURs within the HE context of Kazakhstan. The findings of the study contribute to the ongoing discourse on the globalisation of HE and its impact on developing countries. Drawing on interviews with academics and university leadership, it provides valuable insights into diverse perspectives on the integration of Western practices in the country's HE landscape. The findings suggest that integrating certain successful aspects of the Western university model can enhance universities' research performance and foster stronger university-industry collaboration. However, this integration must be carefully balanced to preserve national priorities. Concerns about the potential loss of national identity and the marginalisation of local educational characteristics highlight the challenges of balancing global academic norms with the local context. These concerns reflect the neo-colonial implications of GURs, which often privilege Western academic norms, thereby marginalising the unique cultural and educational characteristics of developing nations.

While GURs and the integration of Western academic standards aim to enhance the global competitiveness of HE systems, their uncritical application can have unintended consequences. The pursuit of international recognition through Western benchmarks risks perpetuating inequalities and promoting a homogenised academic culture that marginalises diverse traditions and priorities. This reflects broader patterns of academic imperialism, where the dominance of the Global North continues to shape global HE policies. The study concludes that the government's implementation of Western policies, without adequate consideration of local contexts and the research capacities of universities, results in a distorted version of the Western university model.

Based on the findings of the study, several recommendations for policy and practice are proposed. First, policymakers and university leadership should focus on developing a strategic framework that leverages the benefits of global engagement, including participation in GURs, while fostering HE system that capable of addressing the country's unique challenges and opportunities. This approach can ensure that Kazakhstan's HEIs continue to evolve as globally competitive institutions without losing their local priorities. Second, the government should take a selective approach when incorporating Western academic models. While global standards can serve as useful benchmarks, it is essential to adapt these models to fit Kazakhstan's unique cultural, historical, and socio-economic realities. To achieve this, the government could develop a national university evaluation framework that complements GURs by including locally relevant indicators such as societal impact, teaching quality, and research in Kazakh and Russian languages. Third, the government should introduce competitive research grants that prioritise research that addresses national development challenges, supports interdisciplinary collaboration, and encourages partnerships with local industries and communities. Finally, policymakers and university leadership should critically engage with the neo-colonial implications of GURs and Western academic norms. This requires fostering dialogue among stakeholders to ensure HE reforms promote equity and national interests.

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Data availability statement

The data utilised in this study are not publicly available due to confidentiality concerns but can be provided by the author upon reasonable request.

Ethics approval and consent to participate

This study was approved by the Research Ethics Committee of the School of Education, University of Bristol (Ref: 0360). All participants gave their informed consent to participate in the study.

ORCID

Aigerim Bayanbayeva  <http://orcid.org/0009-0006-9738-4881>

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